A COMBATIVE HEAD START

KCR IS SEEKING A THIRD TERM, BANKING ON A SLEW OF SOCIAL WELFARE SCHEMES AND STATEHOOD EMOTIONS, BUT ALLEGATIONS OF CORRUPTION AND ANTI-INCUMBENCY MAY STYMIE HIS HAT-TRICK

By **AMARNATH K. MENON**



PINK WAVE KCR greets supporters

"**The people of Telangana have blessed** KCR twice. Are you ready to do so a third time? This will be the first hat-trick for a chief minister in south India." It is with this impassioned appeal that the ruling Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) is going to the people, seeking votes for its founder and chief minister K. Chandrashekar Rao—popularly known as KCR—who is fighting for a third successive term in the state that goes to the polls on November 30. The appeal is underlined by a catalogue of Direct Benefit Transfer schemes that KCR has initiated for the state's marginalised communities.

Since clinching his party's first electoral victory in 2014, after the state was formed out of the northern parts of undivided Andhra Pradesh, KCR has endeavoured to catapult Telangana on a high-growth trajectory. Early initiatives in infrastructure enhancement, expansion of irrigation and the efficient management of power resources—coupled with increased investments in industry and information technology—have boosted the state's economy. The results have been tangible enough. At Rs 3.12 lakh, Telangana's per capita income (PCI) is the third-highest in the country—after Sikkim and Goa—per the 2022-23 data released by the Union ministry of statistics and programme implementation. It has surpassed the national average of Rs 1.72 lakh; when it was formed, the state's PCI was a mere Rs 1.12 lakh. The Gross State Domestic Product (GSDP) traces a similar upward graph, surging from Rs 4.51 lakh crore in 2014 to Rs 13.1 lakh crore now. With a growth rate of 12.1 per